

Technical Hiring Guidelines & Criteria

AI Engineers • Cloud Engineers • DevOps Engineers • General Business Roles

Purpose

This document provides a shared framework for evaluating candidates across technical and business roles. It is meant to standardize what “good” looks like at each stage of the hiring process so that interviewers, hiring managers, and recruiters are aligned on criteria before conversations with candidates begin.

General Hiring Principles

- Evaluate against the role, not the resume — credentials and pedigree are signals, not requirements.
- Use structured interviews with consistent questions across candidates for the same role.
- Separate technical assessment from culture/values assessment; do not let one bleed into the other.
- Every interviewer submits independent written feedback before any group discussion.
- Prefer evidence of real-world problem solving (past projects, take-home exercises, system walkthroughs) over trivia.
- Be explicit about must-haves vs. nice-to-haves before the role is posted.

AI Engineer

Builds and ships applications and systems that use machine learning or large language models in production — not purely research-focused.

Criterion	What to look for
Core technical skills	Python proficiency; experience with an ML/LLM framework (PyTorch, TensorFlow, or an LLM S
Systems thinking	Can reason about latency, cost, and reliability trade-offs when deploying models, not just mode
Data judgment	Understands data quality, bias, and evaluation methodology; can design a reasonable eval for a
Production experience	Has shipped at least one ML/AI feature that real users depended on, including monitoring and i
Collaboration	Can explain model behavior and limitations clearly to non-ML stakeholders (product, business).

Suggested interview stages: technical screen (Python + ML fundamentals) → system design (e.g., design a RAG pipeline or recommendation system) → applied exercise (debug or extend a small model pipeline) → values/collaboration interview.

Cloud Engineer

Designs, provisions, and maintains cloud infrastructure that other teams build on top of.

Criterion	What to look for
Core technical skills	Deep familiarity with at least one major cloud provider (AWS, GCP, or Azure); networking fundamentals
Infrastructure as code	Hands-on experience with Terraform, CloudFormation, or Pulumi; can review and reason about code
Security awareness	Understands IAM least-privilege design, secrets management, and common cloud misconfigurations
Cost awareness	Can estimate and reason about the cost implications of an architecture decision.
Operational maturity	Comfortable with monitoring, alerting, and incident response for infrastructure they own.

Suggested interview stages: technical screen (cloud fundamentals + scripting) → architecture design exercise → IaC code review exercise → values/collaboration interview.

DevOps Engineer

Builds and maintains the systems, pipelines, and practices that let engineering teams ship software reliably and frequently.

Criterion	What to look for
Core technical skills	CI/CD pipeline design (e.g., GitHub Actions, GitLab CI, Jenkins); containerization (Docker) and orchestration (Kubernetes)
Automation mindset	Default instinct is to automate repeatable manual work; can point to specific examples of doing so
Reliability engineering	Familiar with SLOs/SLIs, on-call practices, and postmortem culture; understands the difference between availability and reliability
Cross-team fluency	Can work effectively with both software engineers and infrastructure/cloud teams; understands the needs of both
Scripting ability	Solid scripting skills (Bash, Python, or Go) for tooling and automation, not just configuration.

Suggested interview stages: technical screen (CI/CD + scripting) → troubleshooting/incident-response simulation → pipeline design exercise → values/collaboration interview.

General Business Roles

For non-technical roles (e.g., operations, sales, marketing, people), apply the same structured process with criteria adapted to the function. As a baseline:

Criterion	What to look for
Role clarity	Candidate understands what the role actually does day-to-day, based on how they answer scenario questions
Ownership	Can point to specific outcomes they were accountable for, including ones that didn't go well and how they handled them
Communication	Communicates clearly and concisely in writing and speech; this is assessed directly during the interview
Judgment under ambiguity	Can make a reasonable decision with incomplete information and explain their reasoning.
Alignment with values	Demonstrates behavior consistent with company values through specific past examples, not general statements

Evaluation & Decision Process

- Each interviewer rates independently on a shared scale (e.g., Strong No / No / Yes / Strong Yes) with written justification.
- Hiring decisions are made in a debrief where every interviewer's evidence is discussed, not just the average score.
- A single strong objection backed by specific evidence should be enough to pause a decision for further discussion.
- Reference checks focus on verifying specific claims made during interviews, not general impressions.
- Document the reasoning for every hire and every rejection for consistency and future calibration.

This is a general-purpose framework and should be adapted to your organization's specific needs, compliance requirements, and interview bandwidth.